

against Hippocoön, king of Sparta, and his sons, who had given assistance to Neleus. Iphicles was killed in this campaign. While returning home from Sparta, Heracles lay at Tegea with Auge, whose father, fearing an oracle that Auge's son would kill her brothers, had made her priestess of Athena. The son she conceived was Telephus, and mother and baby crossed the sea to Asia Minor floating in a chest. There Telephus eventually became king of the Mysians.²⁰

In Thessaly, Heracles appeared as an ally of Aegimius, king of the Dorians, against the attacks of his neighbors, the Lapiths and the Dryopes. This legend brings Heracles back to central Greece, where the legends of the last part of his life are placed.

Heracles, Deïanira, and Iole

Marriage to Deïanira

Some time after the completion of the Labors, Heracles fulfilled the promise he had made to the soul of Meleager to marry his sister Deïanira, daughter of Oeneus, king of Calydon. To win her, Heracles had to wrestle with the river-god **Acheloüs**, who was horned like a bull and had the power to change himself into different shapes. This is how Sophocles describes the scene (*Trachiniae* 513–525):

They came together desiring marriage; alone between them as umpire was Aphrodite, maker of marriages. Then was there confusion of sounds, the beating of fists, the twang of bow, the clash of bull's horns. There were the wrestling holds, the painful collision of heads, and the groans of both. But she, the prize, fair and delicate, sat afar upon a hill, waiting for him who was to be her husband.

In the struggle, Heracles broke off one of Acheloüs' horns; after his victory, he gave it back, receiving in return the miraculous horn of Amalthea, which could supply its owner with as much food and drink as he wished.²¹ Heracles returned with Deïanira to Tiryns. On the way, the centaur **Nessus** carried Deïanira across the river Evenus. When he attempted to violate her, Heracles shot him with his bow. As Nessus was dying, he advised Deïanira to gather some of the blood that flowed from his wound, which had been caused by an arrow that had been dipped in the Hydra's poison. It would, he said, prevent Heracles from loving any other woman more than he loved Deïanira. She therefore kept the blood, and for a number of years she and Heracles lived at Tiryns, where she bore him children, including a son, Hyllus, and a daughter, Macaria.

Iole

But Heracles fell in love with Iole, daughter of Eurytus, king of Oechalia, who had once taught Heracles archery. Eurytus refused to let him have Iole, even though he won an archery contest that was to decide whose wife Iole should be. Heracles returned to Tiryns, bitter at the insult, and when Iphitus, brother of Iole, came to Tiryns in search of some lost mares, Heracles threw him from the citadel

to his death. For this murder, he had to leave Tiryns, going first to Pylos, where Neleus refused to purify him. Having obtained purification at Amyclae, he went to Delphi to find out what more he should do to be cured of the madness that had caused him to kill Iphitus. When the Pythia would not reply, he attempted to carry off the sacred tripod, intending to establish an oracle of his own (see illustration on p. 572). Apollo himself wrestled with him to prevent this theft, and their fight ended when Zeus threw a thunderbolt between them. Finally, Heracles obtained the advice he had asked for, which was that he must be sold as a slave and serve for one year.

Omphale

Accordingly, Hermes auctioned Heracles, and he was bought by Omphale, queen of the Lydians; he served her for a year and performed various tasks for her in keeping with his heroic character. Later versions, however, make Heracles perform women's work for the queen and picture him dressed as a woman and spinning wool. At the end of his year, he mounted the expedition against Troy and then returned to Greece, determined to punish Eurytus and to win Iole.

The Death of Heracles

Deianira, meanwhile, was living in Trachis, where King Ceyx had received her and Heracles after they left the Peloponnese. According to Sophocles, whose *Trachiniae* is the most important source for the last part of Heracles' life, she knew nothing of Oechalia and Iole until the herald Lichas brought news of the sack of the city. She had not seen Heracles for fifteen months, before his servitude to Omphale. In this account, Heracles killed Eurytus and sacked Oechalia on his way back from Asia, sending Iole and the other captive women back to Trachis with Lichas. When she realized that Heracles loved Iole, Deianira, hoping to win him back, dipped a robe in the blood of Nessus and sent it to Heracles by Lichas' hand for him to wear at his thanksgiving sacrifice to Zeus.

As the flames of the sacrificial fire warmed the poisoned blood, the robe clung to Heracles and burned him with unendurable torment. In his agony, he hurled Lichas to his death in the sea and had himself carried back to Trachis, where a huge funeral pyre was made for him upon Mt. Oeta. Deianira killed herself with a sword when she realized what she had done, while Hyllus went with his father to Oeta. There Heracles instructed Hyllus to marry Iole after his death and gave his bow to the shepherd Poeas (father of Philoctetes), since he alone had dared to light the pyre. So the mortal part of Heracles was burned away and he gained immortality, ascending to Olympus, there to be reconciled with Hera and to marry her daughter Hebe. This is Pindar's version (*Isthmian Odes* 4. 61–67):

To Olympus went Alcmena's son, when he had explored every land and the cliff-girt levels of the foaming sea, to tame the straits for seafarers. Now beside Zeus he enjoys a perfect happiness; he is loved and honored by the immortals; Hebe is his wife, and he is lord of a golden palace, the husband of Hera's daughter.



Nessus and Deianira, by Guido Reni (1575–1642); oil on canvas, 1623, 104 × 77 in. Reni painted a series of four scenes from the life and death of Heracles for Ferdinando Gonzaga, Duke of Mantua, in 1621. When the original *Nessus and Deianeira* was removed to Prague (where it still is) during the sack of Mantua by the troops of Charles V, Reni replaced it with this splendid and romantic interpretation of the myth. The young centaur, triumphant in his conquest, bears off Deianira, who twists away as she realizes the fate that has overtaken her, while Heracles in the background takes an arrow from his quiver. Thus Reni focuses on the joy of the centaur, soon to be turned to tragedy for himself, Deianira, and Heracles. The contrast with the stark realism of the Attic artist's painting on the seventh-century B.C. vase on p. 573 is a remarkable example of the way in which the same myth can inspire different emotions. (*Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Heracles and Apollo Struggle for the Pythian Tripod. Attic red-figure amphora by the Andocides painter, ca. 520 B.C.; height of vase 22 ½ in. Athena is armed with helmet, spear, and shield, and her aegis is tasseled with snakes, with a Gorgon's head at the center. She stands at the left watching Heracles and Apollo struggling for the Pythian tripod. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)

Sophocles' *Trachiniae* ends with Heracles, in torment, being carried from his palace to the pyre on Mt. Oeta. In this scene, Hyllus says: "No one foresees what is to come" (1270), thus leaving the destiny of Heracles shrouded in ambiguity. Ovid's description is explicit (*Metamorphoses* 9. 239–272):

And now . . . the flames were attacking the limbs that did not fear them and him who despised them. The gods were anxious for earth's champion [Hercules] and them did Jupiter . . . in happiness thus address: "Your fear is my joy, O gods . . . let not your hearts tremble with empty fear, despite Oeta's flames! He who conquered all will conquer the flames which you see, and only his mother's part will feel the power of Vulcan [i.e., fire]. That part which he inherited from me is immortal, immune to death, impervious to fire, and it will I receive in the heavens when its time on earth is done. . . ." 10
The gods approved. Meanwhile, Vulcan had consumed all that fire could consume, and the recognizable form of Hercules was no longer to be seen. He kept no part of himself that came from his mother, and he kept only the features drawn from Jupiter. . . . So, when the hero of Tiryns had put off his mortal body, his better part kept its vigor. He began to seem greater in size and awe-inspiring with august dignity. The almighty Father received him as he ascended into the surrounding clouds in a four-horse chariot, and placed him among the shining constellations. 20

Heracles: Man, Hero, and God

Odysseus describes his meeting with the ghost of Heracles in this way (Homer, *Odyssey* 11. 601–603):

Then saw I mighty Heracles—his ghost, but he himself delights in feasting among the immortal gods, with fair-ankled Hebe for his wife.

In this very early passage, the ambiguity of Heracles' status as man and god is evident. That he was a man before he became a god is shown by his name (which means "glory of Hera"), since Greek gods do not form their names from compounds of other gods' names. Certainly Euripides, in his tragedies *Alcestis* and *Heracles*, portrays him more as a mortal than a god, as can be seen, for example, in the scene from the *Heracles* in which Lyssa, the goddess of madness, is sent by Hera to torment Heracles.

Since his legend is particularly associated with Argos, Mycenae, and Tiryns, Heracles' saga may have had its origin in a prince of Tiryns who was vassal to the lord of Mycenae. This fits with the theme of subservience to Eurystheus. But other areas with which Heracles is especially associated are Boeotia (the traditional setting of his birth and of a group of his exploits) and Trachis, the scene of his final exploits and death.



The Death of Nessus. Detail of an Attic black-figure amphora, ca. 620 B.C.; height of vase 48 in., of painting 14 in. The scene is painted on the neck of the vase, with owls, a swan, and a pigeon on the handles. The names of Heracles (written right to left) and Nessus (spelled "Netos") are given. Heracles finishes Nessus off with a sword, grasping his hair and violently thrusting his left foot into the Centaur's back. He ignores Nessus' pleas for mercy, shown by the gesture of touching the chin. The hero does not wear the lionskin, nor does he carry his club and bow. (*Nimatallah/Art Resource, NY*)

This leads to one of two possibilities: either legends of the hero of Tiryns spread to Boeotia and other parts of Greece, where his fame attracted local legends, or else he was brought into Greece by early settlers from the north and his fame spread all over Greece. The latter explanation seems the more acceptable, but it has led many people to believe wrongly that Heracles was a Dorian hero, brought in by invaders who entered Greece at the end of the Mycenaean Age. It is better to suppose that Heracles is an older hero common to all the Greek peoples but associated more with certain areas (Argos, Thebes, Trachis) than with others. Thus we find his exploits covering the whole of the Greek world and his legends and cult flourishing in areas of Greek colonization, such as Asia Minor and Italy (where as Hercules he passed into the Roman state religion).

Many people have thought of Heracles primarily as a god. Herodotus believed that Heracles the god was quite distinct from Heracles the man and that the god was one of the twelve ancient gods of Egypt. He himself even traveled to the Phoenician city of Tyre, whose chief god, Melkart, was identified with Heracles, to find support for his theory. Since the mythology of Melkart is virtually unknown, the similarities between him and Heracles remain unclear; nor can we establish the exact relationship between Heracles and other Oriental figures with whom he shares many similarities, for example, the Israelite hero Samson, the Mesopotamian Gilgamesh, and the Cilician god Sandas. These figures may have contributed elements to the Greek hero's legend. In general, it is safe to reject Herodotus' theory and accept the nearly unanimous view of the ancients that Heracles the man became a god.

Still, the origins of Heracles are a subject of great interest. The similarities to the Eastern figures mentioned are undeniable, as are similarities to

The Apotheosis of Hercules, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on panel, 1636, 11 × 12 ¾ in. In this oil sketch for Philip IV's hunting lodge near Madrid, Rubens represents Ovid's narrative at the moment when Hercules ascends from the pyre to Olympus. The flames can be seen at the bottom left, and the bulky hero (Ovid says that "he began to seem greater in size") climbs on the chariot provided by Jupiter. A flying putto puts the victor's wreath on his head, and a second guides the chariot. Rubens does not show Jupiter, so as not to detract from the focus on the triumphant hero. (Musée Royaux des Beaux-Arts de Belgique, Brussels, Belgium)



the Indian hero Indra, who killed the three-headed monster Visvarupa and released the cattle penned in his cave. The monsters that Heracles overcame, such as the lion and the many-headed Hydra, belong more to Eastern mythology, yet Heracles is very definitely a Greek hero, and his myths are Greek traditional tales. Many different tales, then, have become attached to the hero called Heracles. The process can be seen in the large number of *parerga* that cluster around several of the Labors. Some of the myths have a structure consistent with Propp's Quest (see pp. 13–14), and in these the basic structure of the myth remains, despite its varied appearances. The primitive origins of much of Heracles' mythology are apparent from his violence and brutality. His association with many different types of animals has led some scholars to see in him a kind of "Master of Animals," not least because of his association with cattle, the chief source of food in a pastoral society. There is much that is persuasive in Walter Burkert's conclusion:

*Heracles is, basically, not a heroic figure in the Homeric sense: he is not a warrior fighting warriors, he is mainly concerned with animals, just as he is a savage clad in a skin; and his main job is to tame and bring back the animals which are eaten by man.*²²

The Greek hero, son of Zeus and exemplar of strength and patience, is also the man wielding the primitive weapon of the club and wearing the lionskin,



The Choice of Heracles, by Annibale Carracci (1560–1609); oil on canvas, 1596, 65 $\frac{3}{4}$ × 93 $\frac{1}{4}$ in. Formerly the central painting in the ceiling of the *camerino* (private office) of the Farnese Palace, Carracci's painting is a lucid interpretation of Prodicus' parable. Heracles, identified by his club and lionskin, ponders the choice of Pleasure (to the viewer's right), whose attributes include an actor's mask and a musical instrument. On the other side, Virtue, holding a sheathed sword, points to the rocky upward path, at the top of which stands Pegasus. At the bottom left a poet sits ready to record the deeds of the hero, whose eyes indicate that he has already made his choice of Virtue. In the central background is a palm tree, source of the future victor's wreath. (*Galleria di Capodimonte, Naples, Italy*)

whose origins lie perhaps far from Greece and certainly in a time long before the development even of Mycenaean culture.

So diverse a character attracted a variety of interpretations and uses. Indeed, as Aristotle pointed out in the *Poetics* (8), his very diversity made it impossible for a unified epic or tragedy to be written about him. Only three extant Greek tragedies deal with his legend—Sophocles' *Trachiniae* and Euripides' *Heracles* and *Alcestitis*. To the comic poets like Aristophanes, he is good material for slapstick; in the *Frogs*, for example, he is largely motivated by gluttony and lust. Several Greek vases portray him as drinking (and losing) in contests with Dionysus, and in the *Alcestitis* he is entertained by Admetus and given plenty to drink before he learns the truth about Alcestitis.²³

More significant was the use made of his virtues by the moralists and philosophers, to whom Heracles became a model of unselfish fortitude, laboring for the good of humankind and achieving immortality by his virtue. This process is best typified by the famous parable told by Prodicus of Ceos:²⁴ As a young man, Heracles was faced with the choice between two women, representing Pleasure (with ease) and Virtue (with hardship), and chose the latter. Heracles was especially important as a paradigm of virtue in Roman Stoicism, whose doctrines set high value on the Heraclean qualities of endurance and

self-reliance. In a modern setting, the character of Harcourt-Reilly in T. S. Eliot's *The Cocktail Party* (1949) combines the Heracles of the myth of Alcestis with the virtues of a Christlike hero.

Perhaps we would do better to leave Heracles by returning to the ancient invocation to him in the *Homeric Hymn to Heracles, the Lion-Hearted* (15). Here we may focus on the man who after a lifetime of toil became a hero and a god:

Of Heracles will I sing, son of Zeus, whom Alcmena bore in Thebes, city of delightful dances, when she had lain with the son of Cronus, lord of the dark clouds, to be by far the greatest of men on earth. He traversed long ago vast distances of land and sea at the order of King Eurystheus; many were the bold deeds he did, many were the things he endured. Now he dwells in joy in the beautiful palace of snowy Olympus and has for wife slender-ankled Hebe.

Hail, lord, son of Zeus. Grant [me] both excellence and wealth.²⁵

The Heraclidae

Alcmena, Eurystheus, and the Children of Heracles

After the death of Heracles, his mother Alcmena and his children were persecuted by Eurystheus. King Ceyx was unable to protect them, and so they fled to Athens. The Athenians fought Eurystheus, who died in battle with his five sons. His head was brought to Alcmena, who gouged out the eyes with brooches.

According to Euripides, however, in his drama *Heraclidae*, Alcmena and her grandchildren were received at Athens by King Demophon, son of Theseus. Demophon was ordered "by all the oracles to sacrifice a virgin, daughter of a noble father, to the daughter of Demeter [Persephone], to be the defeat of our enemies and the salvation of the city" (*Heraclidae* 407–409, 402). Macaria, daughter of Heracles, voluntarily offered herself for the sacrifice and so brought victory to the Athenians. In the battle, Iolaüs, the nephew of Heracles, was miraculously rejuvenated by Heracles and Hebe and pursued Eurystheus, whom he captured and brought back to Alcmena. The play ends with Alcmena gloating over her prisoner and ordering him off to be executed. With his last words Eurystheus prophesies that his body, if it were buried in Attica, would protect the land from invaders.

Yet another version was given by Pindar (*Pythian Odes* 9. 79–83):

Seven-gated Thebes knew that the Right Time (*Kairos*) favored Iolaüs. Him they buried, after he had cut off the head of Eurystheus with his sword, deep in the earth in the tomb of Amphitryon the charioteer. His grandfather [Amphitryon] lay there, guest of the Spartoi, who lived as a foreigner in Cadmeia, city of white horses.

In this version, Iolaüs killed Eurystheus, and his body, rather than that of Eurystheus, protected the foreign land that had welcomed him—in this case, Thebes (which was Pindar's own city).

Alcmena herself also became associated with a cult. In one version, she died in Thebes and was transported by Hermes to the Elysian Fields, where she

married Rhadamanthys, brother of Minos. In the version of Apollodorus, she married Rhadamanthys in Thebes after the death of Amphitryon, but was reunited with Amphitryon in the Underworld. As she was being carried out to burial in a coffin Hermes, at the command of Zeus, substituted for her body a large stone, which the sons of Heracles discovered (for the coffin had suddenly become very heavy) and set up in a shrine sacred to her.²⁶

The Return of the Heraclidae

The saga of the descendants of Heracles (the Heraclidae) explains the occupation of a large part of the Peloponnese by Dorian tribes in the period after the end of the Mycenaean Age. Hyllus married Iole as his father had commanded and consulted Delphi about his return to the Peloponnese. He was advised to wait “until the third fruit” and was told that victory would come “from the Narrows.” After waiting two more years, Hyllus attacked by way of the Isthmus of Corinth. He himself was killed in single combat by Echemus, king of Tegea; his army withdrew, and a truce of one hundred years was agreed upon. At the end of that time, the Heraclid Temenus again consulted the oracle, who told him that the “third fruit” meant not the third harvest but the third generation, and that “the Narrows” meant the entrance to the Gulf of Corinth. Temenus therefore invaded the northwest Peloponnese, crossing over near Patrae and taking as a guide a “three-eyed man” in accordance with the advice of the oracle; this was an Aetolian exile named Oxylus, whom Temenus found riding a one-eyed horse. With his help, the Heraclids defeated the Peloponnesian defenders, who were led by Tisamenus, son of Orestes. Thucydides (1. 12) relates these events to the disruptions in Greece that followed the Trojan War and the return of the Greek leaders. He says that “the Dorians with the Heraclidae took possession of the Peloponnese in the eightieth year [after the fall of Troy].”

Thus the “Return of the Heraclidae” took place. The leaders divided up the three principal areas that they had conquered. Lacedaemon (Sparta) was given to Procles and Eurysthenes, sons of the lately dead leader Aristodemus, and they became founders of the two royal houses of Sparta. Argos fell to Temenus, and Messene to Cresphontes. Temenus was killed by his sons, whom he had passed over in the succession to his throne. Cresphontes was also murdered, along with two of his sons, by a rival Heraclid, Polyphontes. His widow, Merope, was forced to become Polyphontes’ queen, but she succeeded in getting her surviving son Aepytus out of the kingdom to Aetolia, where he grew up. Later, Aepytus secretly returned to Messene and was recognized by Merope, with whose connivance he killed Polyphontes and recovered his father’s throne. Of the three Dorian kingdoms, Sparta and Argos flourished for many centuries, but Messene was subjugated by the Spartans within a comparatively short time.



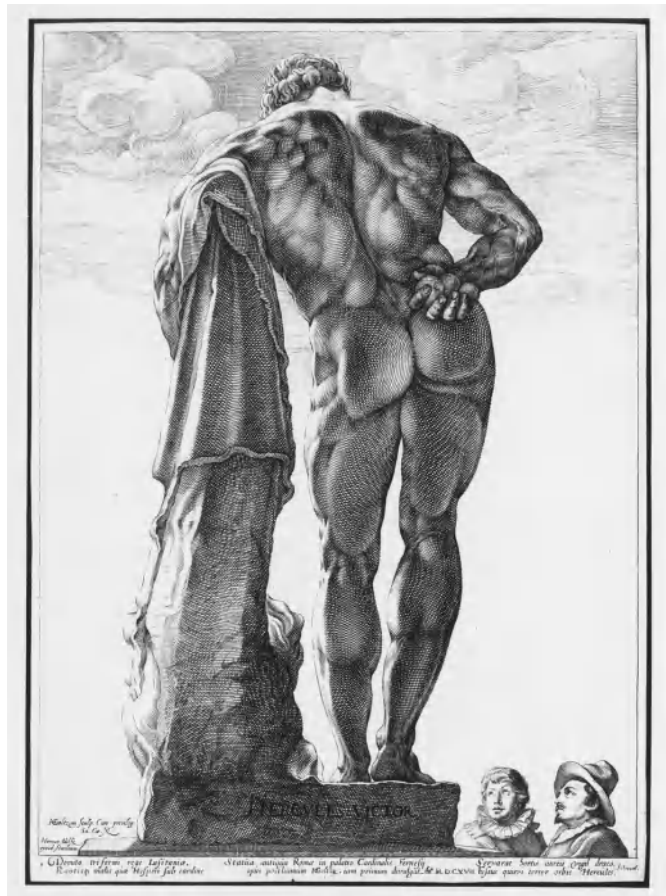
The Farnese Hercules. Marble copy by Glycon, early third century A.D., of an original by Lysippus, mid-fourth century B.C.; height 125 in. This huge statue was found in the Baths of Caracalla at Rome, for which it had been specially copied. The weary hero leans on his club, which rests on a stump over which the lionskin is draped. His vast body is bursting with mountainous muscles. It has been suggested (by M. Robertson) that he is “an athlete in decay”; more likely, his stance is one of weariness after his labors. (Alinari/Art Resource, NY)

Some Later Survivals of the Myth of Heracles

Besides the Pillars of Heracles mentioned here in connection with the tenth Labor, there were many other examples, ancient and more modern, of the desire of political leaders to identify themselves with Heracles. Thus, for example, the Roman emperor Augustus was identified with Heracles on his return from campaigning in Spain in 24 B.C. by the poet Horace (*Odes* 3.14). Horace was thinking of Heracles as the hero who made the world a better place by ridding it of monsters and other threats to civilization. More trivial—indeed ridiculous—was the emperor Nero (d. 68 A.D.), who, it was said at the time of his death, was preparing to fight, in the guise of Heracles, a specially prepared Nemean lion in the amphitheater. More than a century later, the emperor Commodus (d. A.D. 192) gave himself the title of *Hercules Romanus* and was portrayed clothed in Heracles' lionskin and holding the apples of the Hesperides (see p. 642).

In Europe, the image of the “Gallic” Heracles was well known in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. This Heracles had his origin in the *Herakles* of Lucian, a Greek author of the second century A.D. According to Lucian, this “Celtic” Heracles was an old man, with the traditional emblems of the lionskin,

Hercules Victor (The Farnese Hercules), by Hendrik Goltzius (1558–1617). Engraving 1589; published 1617. Goltzius's engraving shows the overmuscular body of the hero from the rear, clutching the Apples of the Hesperides in his right hand. The two contemporary observers emphasize the vastness of his body silhouetted against the sky. The Latin iambic lines (to the left and right of the caption) say: “I, Hercules, terror of the world, rest, weary after subduing the three-formed king [Geryon] of further Spain and after taking the apples from the turning-point of Hesperus, where the never-sleeping serpent had guarded them in gardens of gold.” (*V&A Images, London/Art Resource, NY*)



the club, and the bow, but was also an orator who drew people to himself by the power of his rhetoric. Renaissance handbooks show him as an old man from whose tongue chains extend to his audience, who follow him willingly, overcome by his rhetoric. The Gallic Heracles was used especially in French political imagery: For example, King Henri IV was welcomed into Avignon in 1600 as “L’Hercule Gaulois,” and seven arches decorating the processional route celebrated his Labors.

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For further material see notes 25 and 26 below.

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Euripides	<i>Heracles</i> 352–427
Homer	<i>Iliad</i> 19.103–105
	<i>Odyssey</i> 11.601–603, 620–633
Homeric Hymn 15	<i>To Heracles, the Lion-Hearted</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 9.239–272
Pindar	<i>Isthmian Ode</i> 4.61–67
	<i>Nemean Ode</i> 1.33–72
	<i>Pythian Ode</i> 9.79–83
Sophocles	<i>Trachiniae (Women of Trachis)</i> 513–525

Additional Sources

Apollodorus	<i>Library</i> 2.4.5–2.8.5
Apollonius of Rhodes	<i>Argonautica</i> 1.1153–1357
Euripides	<i>Heracidae</i> (Children of Heracles)
Herodotus	2.43.1–2.45.3 (the Egyptian Heracles)
Plautus	<i>Amphitryon</i>
Seneca	<i>Hercules Furens (The Madness of Hercules)</i>
	<i>Hercules Oetaeus (Hercules on Mt. Oeta)</i>
Xenophon	<i>Memorabilia</i> 2.1.21–2.1.34 (Heracles at the crossroads)

Notes

1. The Greek form of his name, which means “glory of Hera,” is used here. Its Latin form is Hercules. He is also called Alcides (i.e., descendant of Alcaeus) and sometimes Amphitryoniades (i.e., son of Amphitryon).
2. Licymnius, surviving son of Electryon, was later killed by a son of Heracles.
3. According to Apollodorus, Amphitryon was helped by Creon after ridding Thebes of a monstrous fox with the aid of Cephalus and his magic hound (see pp. 585–587).
4. Eileithyia sat outside Alcmena’s door with her hands clasped around her knees in a gesture of sympathetic magic. Alcmena’s servant Galanthis broke the spell by

rushing out crying, "My mistress has borne a son!" Eileithyia leaped up and unclasped her hands, and the birth took place. She punished Galanthis by turning her into a weasel.

5. Eurytus was grandson of Apollo and king of the Euboean city of Oechalia. See p. 570 for his death at the hands of Heracles.
6. The Cattle of Geryon, the Apples of the Hesperides, and Cerberus.
7. Although the hind is female, it is always shown with horns. Euripides makes the hind destructive, and some authors call it the Cerynitian hind, from the Achaeian river Cerynites.
8. Atlas was the name of a mountain in Arcadia as well as of the more famous range in North Africa.
9. The hind is shown beside the tree of the Hesperides in a vase painting.
10. *Parerga* are adventures incidental to the Labors.
11. Pausanias attributes the founding of the games to "Heracles the Dactyl," an attendant of the great Cretan goddess. He had nothing to do with the Greek hero Heracles.
12. The attributes of the birds vary with the imagination of individual authors. See D'Arcy W. Thompson, *Glossary of Greek Birds*, 2d ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1936), p. 273. The birds are later encountered by the Argonauts on the Island of Ares (see p. 612).
13. There are many folktale elements in the legend, for example, the bridegroom's task, the magician who can understand the speech of animals, and the cure of disease by sympathetic magic (cf. Telephus, pp. 485-486).
14. The Spanish painter Francesco Zurbarán (1598-1664) painted a series of ten canvasses for Philip IV of Spain to be placed in the Palace of Buen Retiro in Madrid (they are all now in the Prado), thus continuing the theme of Heracles' importance to the Spanish monarchy.
15. The killing of Cacus is one of the *parerga* to this labor (see pp. 673-675).
16. The Agathyrsi and Geloni were tribes to the north of Scythia, which was the area between the Danube and the Don.
17. His name means "the house of Osiris." Herodotus points out that the Egyptians did not practice human sacrifice.
18. The combat is described in the pseudo-Hesiodic poem, *The Shield of Heracles*. This Cyncus (whose name in Greek means "swan") is one of several mentioned in various poems.
19. Vergil describes this in the sixth *Eclogue* (6.44): *ut litus Hyla, Hyla omne sonaret* ("so that the shore echoed to the cries of 'Hylas, Hylas.'")
20. There are many variants of the legend of Telephus, about whom both Sophocles and Euripides wrote tragedies.
21. This is the *cornu copiae* (horn of plenty). Amalthea is the name of a goddess of Plenty and of the goat that suckled the infant Zeus. Ovid says that the horn of Achelöus became the cornucopia when the Naiads picked it up and filled it with fruit and flowers.
22. Walter Burkert, *Structure and History in Greek Mythology and Ritual* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1979), p. 94.
23. The "comic" Heracles is well described by Galinsky, Chapter 4.
24. Xenophon, *Memorabilia* 2. 21-34; Cicero, *De Officiis* 1. 118. The parable has been very important in Western art: see E. Panofsky, *Hercules am Scheideweg* (Leipzig, 1930).
25. For further discussion, see L. R. Farnell, *Greek Hero-Cults and Ideas of Immortality* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1921), Chapters 5-7, and G. Karl Galinsky, *The Herakles Theme* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1972). The best discussion is that of Burkert, *Structure and History*. For Heracles in art, see Frank Brommer, *Herakles*, 2 vols. (Darmstadt, Germany: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1972-1984); vol. 1 has

been translated by Shirley J. Schwarz as *Heracles: The Twelve Labors of the Hero in Ancient Art and Literature* (New Rochelle, NY: Caratzas, 1984). See also Jane Henle, *Greek Myths: A Vase Painter's Notebook* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1973), pp. 231–238.

26. For the different versions of her myth, see J. G. Frazer's notes on pp. 181–182 and 303 in vol. 1 of his edition of *Apollodorus* (Cambridge, MA: Loeb Classical Library, Harvard University Press, 1961 [1921]).

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Theseus and the Legends of Attica



Descendants of Erechtheus, fortunate from of old and children of the blessed gods, dwelling in a land that has never been ravaged, feeding on most famous wisdom . . .

—EURIPIDES, *Medea*, 824–829

The Early Kings and Their Legends

Cecrops, Erichthonius, and Erechtheus

The Athenians boasted that they were **autochthonous** (literally, “sprung from the earth”), that is, that they were not descended from any invaders of Attica. They said that Cecrops, their earliest king, had sprung from the earth and was serpent-shaped in the lower half of his body. He has little importance in legend except as the founder of Attica, which he called Cecropia after himself. It was in his time that the contest between Poseidon and Athena for the possession of Attica took place (see pp. 177–178). Poseidon continued to be an important divinity at Athens, and his worship on the Acropolis was closely connected with that of Athena.

Another early figure in Attic mythology is Erichthonius, who was also partly serpent-shaped and (as the element *-chthon-* in his name implies) sprung from the earth. When Hephaestus attempted to violate Athena, his semen fell on the ground, and from it sprang Erichthonius. Athena took him up and put him in a chest, which she gave to the daughters of Cecrops, Pandrosos, Auglauros, and Herse (or only to Pandrosos), forbidding them to look inside. The sisters disobeyed: driven mad by what they saw (either a pair of snakes or Erichthonius



The Discovery of the Infant Erichthonius, by Peter Paul Rubens (1577–1640); oil on canvas, ca. 1616, 85 × 125 in. Rubens has painted the moment when Aglauros has opened the basket containing Erichthonius and shows him to her sisters, Pandrosos (on the right) and Herse (on the left) with a brilliant red robe. Cupid gestures toward her as the future bride of Mercury. Behind is a fountain of the many-breasted Artemis, whose fertility is echoed by the herm of the lascivious god Pan, on the left. The identity of the old woman is not known. (Courtesy of the Collections of the Prince of Liechtenstein, Vaduz Castle, Liechtenstein)



Closer Look

with his snakelike body), they hurled themselves off the Acropolis.¹ After this, Athena took Erichthonius back and brought him up herself. As king of Athens, he was credited with instituting the great annual festival of the Panathenaea and setting up the wooden statue of Athena on the Acropolis.

Erichthonius' myth focuses on his birth, the most important feature of which is that he was "sprung from the earth." He is to some extent confused with his grandson and successor as king of Athens, Erechtheus. Both are in fact forms of Poseidon. Athena prophesied that after his death Erechtheus would be worshiped at Athens with his own cult-site, "ringed around with stones," and that under the title of "**Poseidon-Erechtheus** he will be offered sacrifices of bulls."²

Toward the end of the fifth century, the beautiful temple on the Acropolis known as the **Erechtheum** was dedicated jointly to **Athena Polias** (i.e., Athena as Guardian of the City) and Erechtheus.³ In it were sacred objects associated with the earliest stages of Athenian religion, including the wooden statue of Athena, the tomb of Erechtheus, and the salt spring produced by the blow of Poseidon's trident in his contest with Athena, which was known as "the sea of Erechtheus." In this "sea" were the marks of Poseidon's trident where he struck the earth, and linked to the sanctuary was the olive tree produced by Athena. The temple

took the name by which it is generally known, Erechtheum, from Erechtheus-Poseidon; but in antiquity it was known officially as “the temple in which is the ancient statue.”

Thus the Erechtheum and its neighboring shrines were closely bound up with the most ancient myths of Athens. It was built upon the Acropolis, the site of the Mycenaean fortress of Athens, and so it linked Athenians to the earliest stages of their city’s history. Athena, the great Olympian protectress of the city, here was associated with both her rival Poseidon and her predecessor, the chthonic divinity Erechtheus. Her triumph in the struggle for the honor of protecting the city was visible nearby in the sculptures of the west pediment of the Parthenon.

Erechtheus was important in the mythology of Athens. He successfully defended Athens in her earliest war, the attack of the Eleusinians led by the Thracian Eumolpus, who was a son of Poseidon and ancestor of the hereditary priests of Eleusis. With the approval of his wife, Praxithea, Erechtheus sacrificed one (or all three) of his daughters to secure the victory for Athens.⁴ In the battle he killed Eumolpus, and for this deed was himself killed by Poseidon, who thrust him into the earth with his trident. The sacrifice of the daughter was a central theme in Euripides’ tragedy *Erechtheus*, in which Praxithea played a prominent part.⁵

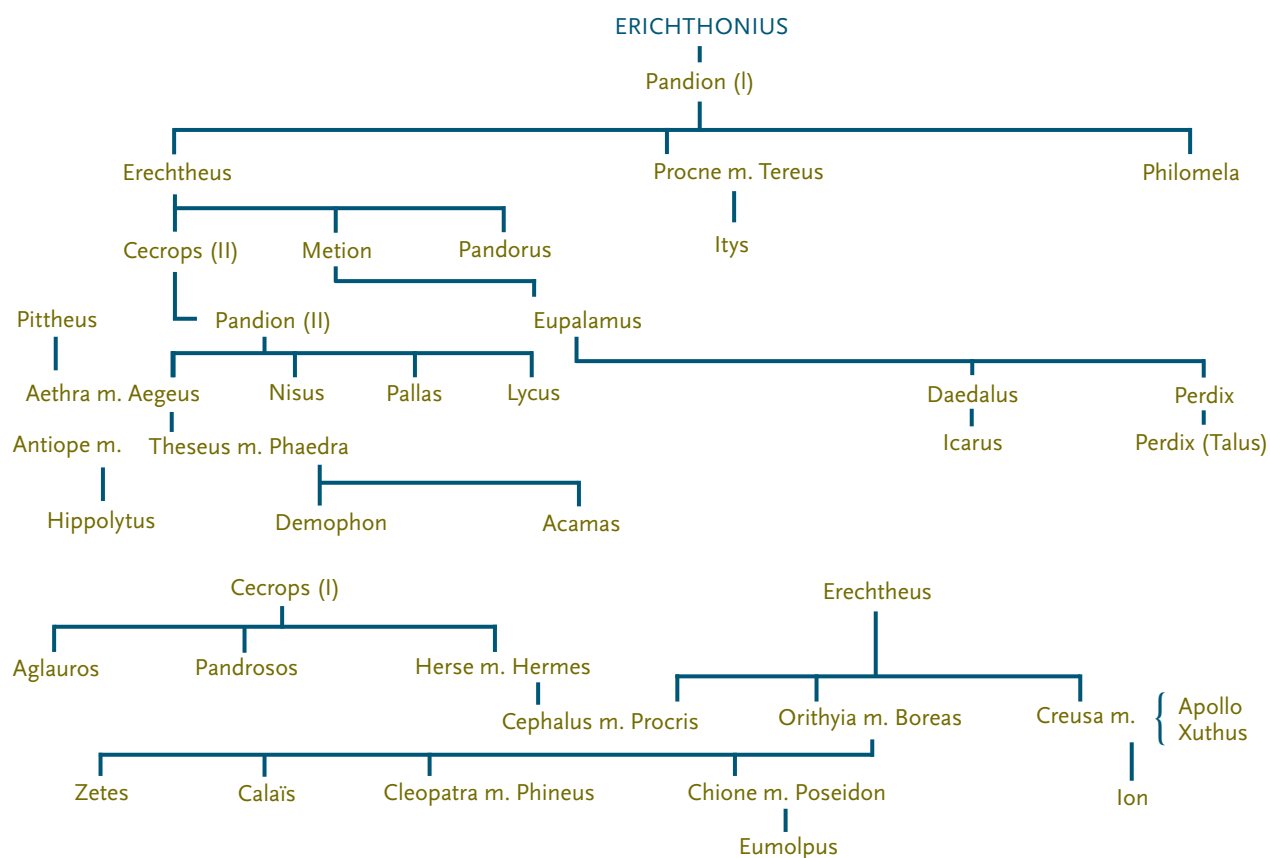


Figure 23.1. The Royal Families of Athens

In Euripides' tragedy *Ion*, Ion's mother, **Creusa**, one of Erechtheus' daughters, gives a different version, in which all the daughters of Erechtheus were sacrificed except for herself (*Ion* 277–282):

ION: Did your father Erechtheus sacrifice your sisters?
 CREUSA: He hardened himself to kill the maidens as a sacrificial offering for the earth.
 ION: How then were you saved alone amongst your sisters?
 CREUSA: I was a newborn baby in my mother's arms.
 ION: And does a chasm in the earth truly hide your father?
 CREUSA: Yes—blows from the ocean-god's trident killed him.

As a final reminder of Erechtheus' importance in Athenian mythology and the pride of the Athenians in being autochthonous, we quote from the opening lines (824–830) of the beautiful chorus in praise of Athens that Euripides composed for his tragedy *Medea*.⁶

The descendants of Erechtheus are fortunate from of old and children of the blessed gods, [dwelling in] a holy land that has never been conquered, feeding on most famous wisdom and walking lightly through the shining air.

We have earlier mentioned the daughters of Cecrops to whom Athena entrusted the infant Erichthonius. They were three in number, Aglauros, Herse, and Pandrosos, whose names, meaning “bright,” “dew,” and “all-dew,” respectively, show that they are truly mythological beings, in origin fertility goddesses.⁷

Ovid tells how Herse was loved by Hermes, who was first noticed by Aglauros as he flew down to the Acropolis. Aglauros asked Hermes for gold as a reward for her help in bringing him to Herse. For this Aglauros further angered Athena, who was already angry because of her disobedience in looking inside Erichthonius' chest. Athena therefore filled Aglauros with such envy that she tried to prevent Hermes from going in to Herse and he turned her into a rock. Hermes then lay with Herse, and their son was Cephalus.

Cephalus and Procris

Cephalus was loved by **Eos (Dawn)** and was an ally of Amphytrion. In later legend, he is the husband of Procris, daughter of Erechtheus. In Ovid's story, Cephalus was tempted by **Aurora** (the Latin form of Eos), who also loved him, to make trial of Procris' faithfulness. In disguise Cephalus attempted to seduce her, and when he was on the point of succeeding, revealed himself. In shame Procris fled and joined Artemis, who gave her a hound, **Laelaps**, that always caught its quarry and a javelin that never missed its mark. Later, she was reconciled to Cephalus and returned home, bringing with her the magic gifts. According to Ovid, the hound was turned into marble, along with its prey, when Cephalus was hunting near Thebes. The javelin had a longer and more tragic history. Here is part of Ovid's story (*Metamorphoses* 7. 804–859; Cephalus is the speaker):

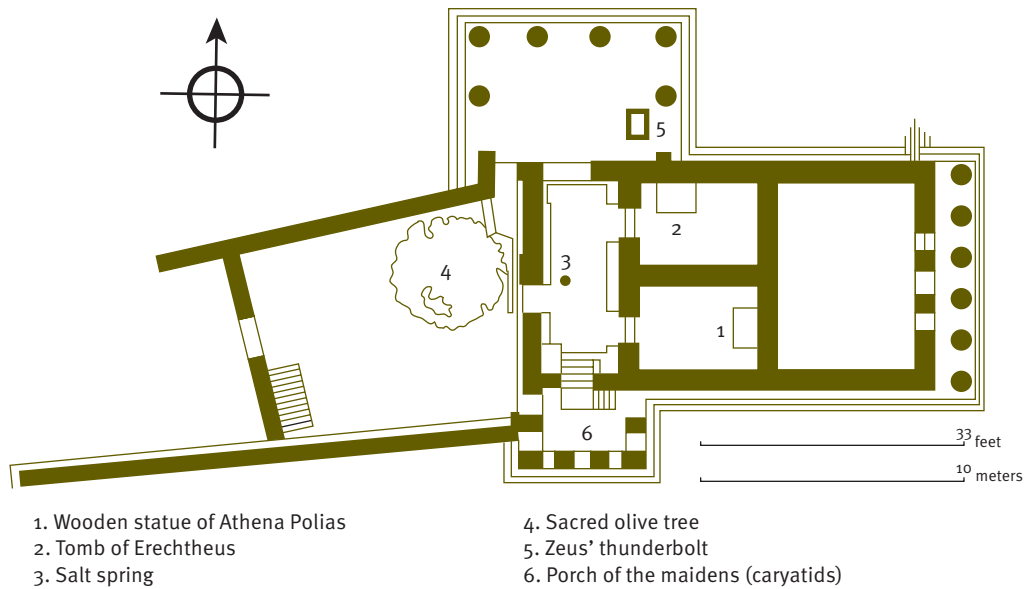


Figure 23.2. Plan of the Erechtheum (after W. B. Dinsmoor)



Audio

When the sun's first rays had just begun to touch the topmost peaks, I used to go, like the young man I was, to the forest to hunt. No servants went with me, nor horses, nor keen-scented dogs trained to follow the knotted hunting nets—all I relied upon was the javelin. When my right hand had had enough of killing wild beasts, I would look for the cool shade and the breeze (*aura*) that came from the cold valleys. The gentle breeze would I call for in the midday heat; the breeze would I wait for, refreshment after my labors. "Come, Aura" (for I remember my words), would I sing, "assist me and most pleasing, enter my bosom; be willing to relieve as you do, the heat with which I burn."⁸ Perhaps I would add (for this way tended my fate) more endearments and would say, "You

10

Someone listening to my words with their double meaning was deceived; thinking the name of *aura* that I called upon so often was the name of a nymph, she believed that it was a nymph I loved. Soon a rash informer falsely charged me before Procris and repeated the murmurings she had heard. Love is credulous, yet often Procris hesitated and refused to believe the informer; she would not condemn her husband's crime unless she saw it herself. (821–834)

The next dawn's light had driven the night away: I went to the forest and, successful in the hunt, lay on the grass and said, "Come, Aura, and give relief to my labor." Suddenly I thought I heard a sob as I spoke, yet still as I was saying, "Come, most excellent Aura," a fallen leaf rustled; and, thinking it was a wild animal, I hurled my javelin through the air. It was Procris; and as she held her wounded breast, she groaned "Ah, me." When I recognized the voice of my faithful wife, headlong I ran to her in dismay. I found her half dead, her blood staining her torn clothes, and plucking her own gift, alas, from the wound. Gently I lifted her body, dearer to me than my own . . . and implored her not to leave me, guilty of her death. (835–850)

20

Weakened and on the point of death, with an effort she said these few words: “By our marriage vows . . . and by my love that still endures, the cause, even as I am dying, of my death, do not let Aura take my place as your wife.” Those were her words; then finally I realized how she had mistaken the name and told her of the mistake. Yet what use was it to tell her? She fainted away, and her feeble strength failed as her blood flowed out.⁹ (851–859)

Philomela, Procne, and Tereus

The successor of Erichthonius was Pandion, who is famous in legend chiefly for his daughters Philomela and Procne. The Thracian king Tereus came to help Pandion in a war against Thebes and was rewarded with the hand of Procne. He took her back to Thrace and by her became the father of **Itys**. Later, Philomela came to visit her sister and was attacked by Tereus, who violated her, cut out her tongue, and shut her up in a remote building deep in the forest. Here is how Ovid continues the story (*Metamorphoses* 6. 572–600):

What could Philomela do? Her prison, with its walls of unyielding stone, kept her from flight. Her mouth, dumb, could not tell of the crime. Yet sorrow is inventive, and cunning is an ally in distress. Skillfully she hung the threads from the barbarian loom and interwove purple scenes with the white threads,



Audio



Cephalus and Aurora, by Nicolas Poussin (1594–1665); oil on canvas, ca. 1630, 38 × 51 ½ in. Cephalus gazes at a portrait of Procris, held up to him by a cupid, as he resists the advances of Aurora. In the background, Pegasus waits to pull the chariot of the Dawn. The sleeping god with the urn is a river-god used by Poussin to signify a mythological landscape. (© National Gallery, London/Art Resource, NY)

telling of the crime. She gave the finished embroidery to a servant and by signs asked her to take it to her mistress. The servant, not knowing what she was bringing, obeyed and took the embroidery to Procne. The cruel tyrant's wife unrolled the tapestry and read the unhappy saga of her own misfortunes. She held her peace (a miracle that she could!); sorrow restrained her words. . . . (572–583)

10

Now came the time when the Thracian matrons celebrated Bacchus' triennial feast; Night accompanied their rites. Queen Procne left her palace, garbed in the god's ritual dress and holding the instruments of his ecstasy. . . . In a frenzy, with threatening looks, Procne rushed through the forest with a crowd of followers; driven by the madness of sorrow she pretended, Bacchus, that it was your madness. At length she reached the lonely prison and raised the Bacchic cry, *Εὔοε*; she broke down the doors, seized her sister, and put on her the Bacchic vestments, veiling her face with leaves of ivy. Dragging the stunned Philomela, Procne brought her sister to the palace. (587–600)

Ovid then tells how Procne decides to revenge herself upon Tereus by murdering their son Itys (636–645):

Without delay, Procne seized Itys. . . . In a distant part of the lofty palace, as he stretched out his hands (for he saw his fate before him) and cried, "Mother, mother," trying to embrace her, she struck him with a sword, where the chest meets the body's flank, and she did not look away. One wound was enough to kill him, but Philomela cut his throat with a knife. They tore apart his body, while it still retained vestiges of life.

Ovid describes, in considerable detail, how the sisters cooked Itys and served him up to Tereus, who recognized too late what he had eaten. The tale continues (666–674):

Now Tereus drew his sword and pursued the daughters of Pandion: you would think that their bodies were clothed with feathers, and indeed they were. One flew to the forest; the other to the roof, and still the murder marked her breast and her feathers were stained with blood. Tereus, rushing swiftly in sorrow and in eagerness for revenge, turned into a bird with crested head; a long beak projects in place of his sword; the bird's name is Epops (Hoopoe), and its face seems armed.

In the Greek version of the story, it is the nightingale (Procne) that mourns for her dead son, while the tongueless swallow (Philomela) tries to tell her story by her incoherent chatter. The Latin authors, however, changed the names, making Philomela the nightingale and Procne the swallow.

The *Ion* of Euripides

Pandion was said to have been succeeded as king by Erechtheus, whose myths we discussed earlier. Among his daughters was Creusa, the heroine of Euripides' play *Ion*. Creusa was the only one of the daughters not to have been sacrificed by her father before the battle against Eumolpus. She was loved by Apollo and bore him a son, Ion, whom she exposed out of fear of her father. Ion was



The Banquet of Tereus,
by Peter Paul Rubens
(1577–1640); oil on canvas,
1636–1638, 77 × 105 in.
Procne, wearing a Maenad's
animal skin, shows the head
of their son to Tereus. Behind
her follows Philomela, her
mouth open as if trying to
speak, wreathed with ivy and
carrying the Maenad's thyrsus.
Tereus has kicked over the
table, and he reaches for
his sword with which to kill
Procne. In the background, a
servant watches from a half-
opened door, and a putto
looks on from above. (*Erich
Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

saved by Hermes at Apollo's request and taken by Apollo to Delphi, where he was brought up as a temple servant and became treasurer of the sanctuary. Creusa, meanwhile, was given as wife to Xuthus as a reward for helping Erechtheus defeat the Chalcodontids of Euboea. After years of childlessness, Xuthus and Creusa consulted the Delphic oracle as to how they might have children; Xuthus was told to greet as his son the first person he met on going out of the temple.¹⁰ This person was Ion, but Creusa, who did not know that he was her own son, took him for a bastard son of Xuthus and attempted to kill him. The attempt miscarried, and with the intervention of Athena, mother and son recognized each other. Xuthus, Creusa, and Ion returned together to Athens, where Ion became the ancestor of the four Ionic tribes (which were the main units of the early Athenian political structure). His descendants colonized part of the coast of Asia Minor and the islands, thereafter called Ionia.¹¹

Orithyia and Boreas and Their Children

Another daughter of Erechtheus, Orithyia, was loved by the North Wind, Boreas. He carried her off to Thrace as she was playing by the river Ilissus.¹² In Thrace, she became the mother of the winged heroes **Zetes** and **Calaïs**, and of two daughters, Cleopatra and Chione. Zetes and Calaïs were prominent in the Argonauts' expedition (see p. 612). Phineus was married to Cleopatra, who was said to have caused the blindness of her stepsons (born to Phineus from another woman) by falsely accusing them of attempting to seduce her. Chione became the mother, by Poseidon, of Eumolpus, whose expedition against Athens we discussed earlier.

The Confused Genealogy of the Kings of Athens

According to Apollodorus, Erechtheus was succeeded by his son Cecrops, and Cecrops by his son Pandion; Cecrops and Pandion thus repeat the names of earlier kings. Pandion was driven out of Attica by his uncle Metion and fled to Megara, where he became the father of four sons: Aegeus, Pallas, Nisus, and Lycus. After Pandion's death, the four brothers recovered the throne at Athens and shared the power; Aegeus, however, as the oldest, was in effect the sovereign, while Nisus returned to Megara as its king.

Theseus

Aegeus, like Erechtheus, is another form of the god Poseidon. This is indicated by his connection with the **Aegean Sea** and by the tradition that Poseidon rather than Aegeus was Theseus' father.¹³ As king of Athens, Aegeus was threatened by the opposition of his brother **Pallas**. Being childless, Aegeus was told by the Delphic oracle "not to undo the wineskin's mouth" until he had returned home. Perplexed by this riddle, he asked the advice of **Pittheus**, king of **Troezen**, his host on the journey. Pittheus, who understood the oracle, made Aegeus drunk and gave him his daughter **Aethra** to lie with.¹⁴ When Aegeus left Troezen, he told Aethra that if their child were a boy she must bring him up without saying who his father was. She was to send him to Athens when he was old enough to lift a rock by himself, under which Aegeus would leave a sword and a pair of sandals as tokens by which he could recognize his son. In due time, Aethra bore a son, Theseus, who grew up and set out for Athens after securing the tokens.

Theseus is the great national hero of Attica, and Athens came to be the focal point of his legends. His earlier links with Marathon and Troezen were weakened. He is associated with Heracles in some of his adventures, and his deeds are similar to those of Heracles—for example, his ridding the land of brigands

Mary Renault's Theseus

An entertaining novel retelling the life of Theseus in a very compelling fashion is *The King Must Die* (1958) by Mary Renault, who is exceptional in her ability to make classical mythology and legend come alive. Robert Graves is another so gifted, for example, in his novel *Hercules, My Shipmate* (1945).

Renault has a firm grasp of both the ancient sources and modern archaeology, and by her sensitive art she has re-created the civilization and the characters in a most credible and exciting manner. Dominant among the many political and religious issues in her novel is the overriding motif of Theseus caught in the archetypal battle between matriarchy and patriarchy. This young, inspiring hero could never fall victim to the horrifying, archaic ritual by which the king must die to ensure the dominance and fertility of the earth mother. Renault's sequel, *The Bull from the Sea* (1962), depicts the life of the Amazons, one of whom becomes the mother of Hippolytus.

and monsters and his expedition against the Amazons. Some of the characters in his saga were themselves heroes with cults of their own, for example, Sciron and Hippolytus. The legends of Theseus have become famous largely through the genius of Athenian writers.¹⁵

Theseus' Six Labors on His Journey from Troezen to Athens

The adventures of Theseus fall into fairly well-defined groups,¹⁶ of which the first contains six deeds he performed while traveling to Athens from Troezen. To expose himself to the challenge of more dangerous adventures, Theseus chose the land route.

At Epidaurus he killed the brigand **Periphetes**, a son of Hephaestus, who was armed with a club and generally called **Corynetes (Club Man)**. Theseus took the club for himself, and it plays no further part in his legend (except in artistic representations).

At the Isthmus of Corinth, Theseus killed the robber **Sinis**, called **Pityocampetes (Pine Bender)** from the way in which he killed his victims. He would bend two pine tree saplings to the ground, tie one end of his victim to each of the two trees, and then release the trees. Theseus killed him in this way.

On the border of the Isthmus and the Megarid, Theseus killed a **monstrous sow** near the village of **Crommyon**. Next he found the brigand **Sciron** barring his way at the so-called Cliffs of Sciron. Sciron, originally a local hero of neighboring areas,¹⁷ blocked the path along which travelers through the Megarid must go to pass the cliffs and compelled all comers to stoop and wash his feet. He



The Labors of Theseus. Attic red-figure kylix, ca. 475 B.C.; height of kylix 5 in., diameter 12 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. The cycle of Theseus' labors was often painted on Athenian vases, especially drinking cups (*kylikes*), in the fifth century. This cup is unusual in that the cycle is painted (almost identically, except for the Minotaur) on both the exterior and interior. The interior, with the Minotaur at the center, is shown here. Starting at the top and going in a clockwise direction the labors are: (1) Cercyon; (2) Procrustes; (3) Sciron (note the turtle); (4) the bull of Marathon; (5) Sinis (Pityocampetes); (6) the sow of Crommyon. At the center Theseus drags the dying Minotaur out of the Labyrinth to dispatch him with his sword. Periphetes does not appear, since this labor does not enter the cycle until after 475 B.C. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)



would then kick his victims into the sea, where a gigantic turtle ate them up. Theseus killed him by his own methods.

Drawing closer to Athens, Theseus met **Cercyon** at Eleusis. Like Sciron, Cercyon was also originally a local hero. He compelled travelers to wrestle with him to the death. Theseus defeated him in wrestling, held him high in the air, and then dashed him to his death upon the ground.

Finally, between Eleusis and Athens, Theseus met the brigand **Procrustes** (his name means “**the stretcher**”),¹⁸ who possessed a hammer, a saw, and a bed. He compelled travelers to lie on the bed, and those who were too long for it he would cut down to size; those who were too short he would hammer out until they fit it exactly. He, too, perished at Theseus’ hands in the way in which he had killed his victims.

Theseus Is Recognized by Aegeus

Theseus’ arrival at Athens is dramatically described by the lyric poet Bacchylides of Ceos. In reply to the citizens’ questions, Aegeus speaks (Bacchylides, *Dithyramb* 18. 16–60):

“A messenger has come, traversing the long road from the Isthmus; incredible are the deeds of a mighty man that he relates. This man killed violent Sinis, strongest of mortals. He killed the man-slaying sow in the glens of Crommyon and killed the cruel Sciron. The wrestling ring of Cercyon has he suppressed; Procoptes [Slicer, i.e., Procrustes] has dropped the mighty hammer of Polypemon [Troubler, i.e., Procrustes’ father?], for he has met a more valiant man. I fear what this news portends.” “Who is this man?” [ask the citizens, and Aegeus continues]: “Two companions only come with him, says the messenger; upon his shoulders he wears an ivory-hilted sword, and in his hand he carries two polished spears; upon his red-haired head is set a Spartan cap, well-made; around his body he has cast a purple tunic and over it a woolen cloak from Thessaly. From his eyes darts blood-red flame, as from Lemnos’ volcano. Yet he is but a youth in his first prime, whose skill is in the delight of war and the brazen blows of battle. In quest of shining Athens does he come.” 10

Theseus’ arrival was hedged with further danger. Aegeus was married to **Medea**, who expected their son Medus to succeed as king of Athens. Medea, immediately recognizing Theseus as Aegeus’ son and a rival to Medus, attempted to have Theseus poisoned before Aegeus could recognize him. She advised Aegeus that the newcomer would be a threat to his power. He should entertain Theseus at a banquet where he would drink poisoned wine, for which Medea would provide the poison. Theseus at the banquet carved his meat with the sword that he had recovered from under the rock at Troezen; Aegeus recognized the sword, dashed the cup of poison out of Theseus’ hand, and publicly recognized him as his son and successor.

Pallas, brother of Aegeus, and his sons had hoped and plotted to take over Aegeus’ power and resorted to violence upon Theseus’ recognition. Theseus killed all the members of one of the two groups into which they had divided, and Pallas himself and his surviving sons ceased to be a threat.

The Bull of Marathon

Theseus' next labor was to catch the bull of Marathon, which was said to have been the one that Heracles had brought from Crete. He mastered the bull and drove it back to Athens, where he sacrificed it to Apollo Delphinus. On his way to Marathon an old woman, **Hecale**, entertained Theseus. She promised she would sacrifice to Zeus if Theseus returned successful, but on his return he found her already dead and ordered that she share the honors henceforth paid to Zeus Hecalus at a local annual festival.

The Minotaur

Androgeos, son of the Cretan king **Minos**, had been killed in Attica because of the jealousy he aroused by winning all the contests at the Panathenaic games. In revenge, Minos mounted an expedition against Athens and her ally, Megara, where Nisus, brother of Aegeus, was king. Megara was attacked first, and some time after its fall Athens made a treaty with Minos, with the provision that at intervals (of one or nine years) seven Athenian youths and seven girls, children of noble families, should be sent to Crete as tribute, there to be shut up in the Labyrinth and devoured by the Minotaur. The victims were chosen by lot, and Theseus volunteered to go.¹⁹

On the voyage to Crete, Minos attacked one of the maidens, Eriboea, who called on Theseus for help. When Theseus intervened, Minos prayed to Zeus for a sign that he was indeed Minos' father (and therefore that his son need be under no restraint in dealing with other men). Zeus sent lightning, and Minos then challenged Theseus' claim to be the son of Poseidon by throwing a ring



Theseus and Amphitrite. Attic red-figure cup by the painter Onesimos and signed by the potter Euphronios, ca. 500 B.C.; diameter 15 $\frac{3}{4}$ in. The boyish figure of Theseus is held up underwater by a tiny Triton, as dolphins cavort to the left. Amphitrite, seated on a stool, holds the wreath in her left hand, as Athena (with helmet, spear, and aegis) looks toward her. This scene anticipates the narrative of Bacchylides by some twenty-five years. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

overboard, which Theseus was to recover. A beautiful poem by Bacchylides describes the sequel (*Dithyramb* 17. 92–116):

The Athenian youths trembled as the hero leaped into the sea, and tears poured from their lilylike eyes as they awaited the sorrow of what had to be. Yet the dolphins, dwellers in the sea, swiftly brought great Theseus to the palace of his father, the ruler of horses. There with awe he saw the noble daughters of rich Nereus, and in the lovely palace he saw his father's own wife, the beauteous Amphitrite, in all her majesty. Round him she cast a purple robe, and upon his thick hair the unwithered wreath, dark with roses, which subtle Aphrodite had given her at her own marriage.

With these gifts (the poet does not mention the ring), Theseus returned miraculously to the ship and so came to Crete. There the daughter of Minos, **Ariadne**, fell in love with him and gave him a thread with which he could trace his way back out of the **Labyrinth**. With this aid he entered the Labyrinth, killed the **Minotaur**, and emerged unharmed. He then sailed from Crete with his thirteen Athenian companions, taking Ariadne with him.

Ariadne on Naxos

Another tradition, however, makes Ariadne give Theseus a wreath that lights up the darkness of the Labyrinth and so helps him escape. In the poem of Bacchylides, this wreath is made the gift not of Ariadne but of Amphitrite, so that Theseus himself brings it to Crete. Ariadne wore the wreath on her flight with Theseus until he deserted her on Naxos and she was found by **Dionysus**. The god took the wreath and set it in the heavens, where it became the constellation Corona.

Here is Ovid's version of the metamorphosis (*Metamorphoses* 8. 174–181):

Quickly the son of Aegeus sailed to Dia after seizing Minos' daughter and cruelly left his companion deserted on that shore. Alone and bitterly complaining, Ariadne found comfort in the embraces of Bacchus, who took the wreath from her brow and placed it in the heavens so that Ariadne might be made famous by a constellation. The wreath flies through the thin air, and as it flies its jewels are turned into fires and become fixed in their place, still with the appearance of a wreath (*corona*).

Ariadne is originally a divine person, perhaps another form of Aphrodite. Hesiod (*Theogony* 947–949) describes her as the “wife of Dionysus, whom Zeus made immortal.” Later versions of the Theseus legend make her a forlorn heroine, deserted by her lover Theseus upon the island of Dia (the early name for Naxos) during the voyage back to Athens. Here is the narrative of Catullus (64. 52–59):

Ariadne, with uncontrolled passion in her heart, looking out from the shore of Dia with its sounding waves, saw Theseus receding into the distance with his fleet at full speed. Not yet could she believe her eyes, for she had only just been wakened from deceitful sleep and saw that she was alone, unhappy, upon the shore. But the young man, forgetful, parted the waves with his oars in flight, leaving his promises unfulfilled to the gusts of wind.



Ovid, who related this legend three times,²⁰ describes the arrival of Dionysus and his companions (*Ars amatoria* 1. 535–564):

And now Ariadne beat her soft breast again and again: “My faithless lover has gone,” cried she. “What will become of me?” “What will become of me?” she cried; the shore reechoed to the sound of cymbals and the frenzied beating of drums. She swooned in fear, and her words trailed away; no blood remained in her fainting body. Look! here are the maenads, their hair streaming down their backs. Look! here come the dancing satyrs, forerunners of the god. Look! here is old Silenus, hardly able to keep his seat upon the swaybacked donkey. . . . And now came the god in his chariot decked to the top with vines, driving yoked tigers with golden reins. Ariadne lost her color, her voice, her thoughts of Theseus; thrice she tried to run away, and thrice fear held her rooted. . . . Then said the god: “Behold I am here, a more faithful object of your love. Away with fear! You shall be the Cretan wife of Bacchus. Take the heavens as my gift; you shall be observed in the heavens as a constellation. Often as the Cretan Crown (Corona) will you guide lost sailors.” So he spoke and jumped down from the chariot, lest she be alarmed by the tigers, and took her up in his arms, for she could not resist; all things are easy for a god. Some of his followers chant the marriage cry, “O Hymen,” and others cry, “*Evoe, evoe*,” so the god and his bride lay together in the sacred bed.

Death of a Monster, by Pablo Picasso (1881–1973); pencil on paper, 1937, 15 × 22¼ in. The contorted and dying Minotaur sees himself in a mirror held up by a sea-goddess, perhaps Amphitrite herself. Picasso used the violence and horror of the Minotaur to express his anger at the atrocities of the Spanish Civil War; this drawing is dated December 6, 1937, eight months after the bombing of Guernica. (© 2014 estate of Pablo Picasso/Artist's Rights Society (ARS)/Scottish National Gallery of Modern Art; Purchased with the support of the Heritage Lottery Fund and the Art Fund 1995)

Homer says that Ariadne was killed by Artemis upon Naxos as a punishment for eloping with Theseus when she was already betrothed to Dionysus. Yet another story has her die in Cyprus in giving birth to Theseus' child. When Theseus returned, he instituted a ritual in her honor. In historical times, she was honored under the title of Ariadne Aphrodite, part of the ritual being for a young man to lie down and imitate a woman in childbirth. In all these conflicting stories, it is clear that Ariadne is no ordinary mortal and that her partner was not a man, Theseus, but a god.

Theseus Becomes King of Athens

After leaving Dia (Naxos), Theseus went to Delos, where he sacrificed to Apollo and danced the **Crane dance** with his companions. The dance became traditional at Delos, and its intricate movements were said to imitate the windings of the Labyrinth.²¹ From Delos Theseus sailed home to Athens. Now he had arranged with Aegeus that he should change the black sail of his ship for white if he had been successful. This he forgot to do, and as Aegeus saw the black-sailed ship approaching, he threw himself from a cliff into the sea, which thereafter was called the **Aegean Sea**.

So Theseus became king of Athens. He was credited with a number of historical reforms and institutions, including the **synoecism** of Attica (i.e., the union of the different villages into one political unit with Athens as its center) and the refounding of the **Isthmian Games**.²²

The Amazons

Theseus joined with Heracles in his expedition against the Amazons, and as his share of the spoil received the Amazon, **Antiope**, by whom he became the father of **Hippolytus**. The Amazons in revenge invaded Attica and were defeated by Theseus. During the Amazon attack, Antiope died. The battle between Theseus and the Amazons became a favorite theme in Athenian art after the Persian Wars, when the Amazons were seen as symbols of the barbarians, who, like the Persians, had been defeated by the Greeks.²³

Theseus and Pirithoüs

Pirithoüs, king of the Thessalian tribe of the **Lapiths** and son of Ixion, was Theseus' friend. Theseus was among the guests at the marriage of Pirithoüs and took part in the fight against the **centaurs**, which became an important theme in Greek art.

Theseus and Pirithoüs vowed to help each other in securing a wife. Theseus attempted to take **Helen**, and Pirithoüs, **Persephone**. Helen, who at the time was only a child, was kidnapped from Sparta and brought back to Attica, where she was put in the care of Theseus' mother, Aethra, in the Attic village of Aphidnae. While Theseus and Pirithoüs were away on their attempt against Persephone, the **Dioscuri** invaded Attica and recovered their sister. The Dioscuri were favorably received in Athens itself, where the regent Menestheus instituted a cult in their honor.²⁴ Aethra was taken back to Sparta as Helen's servant and went with her to Troy.



Dionysus and Ariadne. Marble sarcophagus, ca. A.D. 180; width 77 in., height (without lid) 20 ½ in., height of lid 11 in. Dionysus approaches from the left riding on a chariot drawn by a lyre-playing centaur, in front of and to the right of whom a centauress blows on a kind of trumpet. Before him go Pan and a silenus, and a silenus mask lies on the ground in the left center. A cupid hovers near the god. In the center the god stands, now clothed in a long robe, holding a reversed thyrsus in his left hand, his right hand resting on the leading silenus. He looks toward the sleeping Ariadne, whose robe is being drawn aside by a cupid, while two maenads look back at the god. To the right two maenads are about to attack Pentheus. On the lid are reliefs of the god's thiasos, and a deer (far right) is being sacrificed. The waking of Ariadne to the coming of the god of new life was popular in the funerary art of late antiquity as a parable of the waking of the soul to eternal life after death. This sarcophagus is in a tomb in the cemetery under St. Peter's Basilica in the Vatican. It is not known whether its occupant was pagan or Christian. (Photo courtesy of the Foto Fabbrica di San Pietro, Vatican)

Pirithoüs met his end in attempting to abduct Persephone. He and Theseus descended to the Underworld where they were held fast in magic chairs. In the Athenian tradition, **Heracles** interceded for Theseus' release, while Pirithoüs stayed in Hades forever. Thus the Athenian hero was again associated with Heracles, in this case in his last and greatest labor, the conquest of death.

Theseus, Phaedra, and Hippolytus

Theseus was also married to Phaedra, another daughter of Minos, and she bore him two sons, Demophon and Acamas. Phaedra (whose name means "bright") may originally have been a Cretan goddess like Ariadne. As we learned in Chapter 10, she fell passionately in love with Hippolytus, Theseus' son by Antiope, but did not tell him of her desire. During an absence of Theseus, her old nurse found out the secret and told Hippolytus. In shame at the discovery of her secret, Phaedra hanged herself and left behind a letter falsely accusing Hippolytus of attempting to seduce her. When Theseus returned, saw Phaedra's corpse, and read the letter, he banished Hippolytus and called on Poseidon to destroy him.²⁵ As Hippolytus was driving his chariot along



Closer Look



the seashore on his way into exile, Poseidon sent a bull from the sea, which so frightened the horses that they bolted, threw Hippolytus from the chariot, and dragged him almost to his death. He was carried back to Theseus and died after a reconciliation with his father, assured by Artemis of his future honor as a hero with a cult.

The legend of Hippolytus owes its fame largely to Euripides, who wrote two tragedies on the subject (one of which is extant), and to Seneca, whose *Phaedra* was the model for Racine's *Phèdre*.²⁶ In Euripides' *Hippolytus*, the drama is set at Troezen; but most other authors make Athens the scene. Hippolytus himself was honored with a cult at Troezen and was closely connected with Artemis, in whose honor he avoided all women. At Athens he was connected with Aphrodite, whose temple on the south side of the Acropolis was called "Aphrodite by Hippolytus." Hippolytus himself was said to have been brought to life by Asclepius, and in his resurrected form he was absorbed by the Italians with the name of Virbius. His legend is of the greatest literary importance: it connects Attica and Troezen and links Theseus to the great goddesses worshiped in Crete, Troezen, and Athens.

Theseus as Champion of the Oppressed

In the fifth century, a number of legends were developed in which kings of Athens were portrayed as protectors of victims of tyranny who had been driven from their homes. In Euripides' *Medea*, Aegeus, father of Theseus, promises to protect Medea, who has been exiled from Corinth. Theseus was especially popular in these legends. He generously gave refuge to the exiled Oedipus (see pp. 419–423),



Dionysus and Ariadne. Bronze krater (the Derveni Krater), second half of the fourth century B.C.; height 35½ in. The krater, which held the ashes of a Thessalian nobleman, was discovered at Derveni, not far from Thessalonike, in 1962. The reliefs on the central panel show Dionysus, naked, seated on a rock with his leg over Ariadne's thigh. She draws her veil aside, the gesture of a bride accepting her husband. Behind Dionysus is a panther, and birds, animals, vines, and ivy ornament the neck and body of the krater. Figures of maenads flank the divine pair, and in the upper register the seated Dionysus gestures toward a sleeping maenad. The handles, in the form of serpents, frame the head of a horned god to the left and of Heracles (with lionskin over his head) to the right. (Top: Archaeological Museum, Thessaloniki, Greece, © Vanni/Art Resource, NY; Bottom: The Art Archive/Archaeological Museum Salonica/Gianni Dagli Orti)



Closer Look